

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This article was recently published on a news webpage:

American teenagers today are driving less than their parents did

14 years ago, when Zachary Grand turned 17, he couldn't wait to get his driving licence. Back then, a driving licence was considered a sign of adulthood: you were not a child anymore and could travel around freely, not depending on anyone else.

How times have changed. While the share of US teenagers with a driving licence was over 65% in 1995, today it is below 40%. In cities that have good public transport, the percentage is even lower.

Grand notes that teens do not want to get their driving licences anymore. "When I recently moved from California to Chicago, I was really surprised to see that so few young people here want to drive. It's incredible!"

The reasons behind this trend are many, and complicated. For one thing, car costs have increased a lot and so have the prices of petrol and insurance. Additionally, cities and towns have grown more crowded and less car-friendly, and many states in the US have made it harder for teenagers to get a driving licence.

Technology is also a factor. Things that teens used to do in person – hanging out with friends, taking classes, shopping for clothes, playing games – can now be done online. Ride-hailing apps like Uber and home delivery apps have also made driving less necessary.

"You can do anything from your phone," Grand says. "Call an Uber or even book a train or bus if you want to."

Your group is discussing whether it is worth learning to drive in Hong Kong. You may want to talk about:

- the benefits and challenges of being a driver in Hong Kong
- whether Hong Kong is a car-friendly city
- reasons why so few teenagers learn to drive in Hong Kong
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Do you want to learn to drive?
2. Do young people in Hong Kong usually learn to drive?
3. Is Hong Kong a safe city for driving?
4. Do you think schools should teach students how to drive?
5. Do you think it is necessary for teenagers to learn to drive in Hong Kong?
6. Should the government encourage more or less car ownership in Hong Kong?
7. Should Hong Kong young people be allowed to drive at a younger age than 18 years old?
8. Do you think that learning to drive is a sign of adulthood?